The second mission was a disaster. The tunnellers did reach the walls, yes, and found not one but two adjacent spots to pack with gunpowder – 120 and 80 maunds of it, respectively. On 17 December, having lit two fuses for the two ‘mines’, Akbar’s troops waited impatiently to charge their way in. The fire reached the ammunition, there was a great explosion. A whole tower with gunpowder beneath it ‘was sprung into the air’, and with it the soldiers fighting from its heights.[26]

As the tower and its men came crashing to the ground, the Mughals charged. Chittor was breached, they were in!

But no.

Only one of the two stacks of gunpowder had caught fire; the second had a slower fuse. It caught just as the Mughal troops reached the broken tower.

If heavy rocks were propelled several kilometres by this second explosion, then what of men? Soldiers, Mughal and Rajput, ‘flew about like moths in that flood of fire’;[27] their burnt remains littered the surroundings. Others were crushed where they stood, by falling stone. A whole platoon of forty men, crouching in a crevice, ready to pounce, was buried alive in flying debris.

‘A cry of horror,’ writes Badauni, ‘arose from the people of Islam and from the infidels.’ Another historian describes how the air was full of ‘dust and smoke’, how the army could only stare in shock as ‘stones, corpses, and limbs fell from the air’. It was a scene of hellish despair.[28] Between 200 and 500 of Akbar’s men died; the rest were ‘sore distressed, and ready to succumb’.[29] Pouring salt on the Mughals’ gaping wounds, the Rajputs, having escaped with fewer casualties, ‘made fun of the accident’[30] from upon their bastions.

Chittor stood as solid, as unshaken, as ever.

So did Akbar. Neither his own army’s wretched fear, nor his enemy’s piling of insult on injury would distract him. ‘Patience and planning were necessary’, writes Abul Fazl, and Akbar had plenty of both. Inch by inch, his sabat drew closer to his prey.

Akbar’s sabat was a truly Herculean undertaking: wide enough to allow ten horsemen to march through it abreast, tall enough for a man to ride through on an elephant, holding up a spear. The tunnel was also, of course, a highly visible target. And the closer it got the more vulnerable it became.